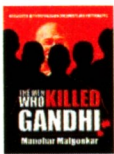




ON TRIAL: (Front row, left to right) Godse, Apte and Karkare; (back row, extreme left) Badge

ANNIVERSARY ADDITION

Some rare photos and documents give this account of Gandhi's assassination a new lease of literary life



THE MEN WHO KILLED GANDHI

by MANOHAR MALGONKAR

Roli Books

Price: Rs 395

Pages: 351

■ By Dilip Bobb

Anniversaries of apocalyptic events raise the marketing antenna of publishers, and no event in Indian history, barring Independence, has as much resonance as Mahatma Gandhi's assassination on January 30, 1948. This book is a reprint of the 1978 original, timed for the 60th anniversary of the event, with some additions in the form of rare photographs and documents unearthed by the publishers and not the author Manohar Malgonkar, now 95 and a virtual recluse.

His account of the conspiracy, 30 years after the event, was a landmark effort that cemented his reputation as a historian. Of the six conspirators, Nathuram Godse, who fired the shot heard around the world, and Narayan Apte, who was by his side, were hanged. The other four were: Digambar Badge, who turned approver; Vishnu Karkare; Gopal Godse, Nathuram's younger brother; and Madanlal Pahwa. Malgonkar met them after they

had served their life sentences and they spoke to him at great length. All four provided information they had not revealed before and Malgonkar produced perhaps the most complete account of the plot to assassinate Gandhi.

Knowing the 60th anniversary of the event was approaching, the publishers decided to produce an illustrated version of Malgonkar's book. While researching, they came across rare and unpublished photographs and documents. Among them

FINAL MOMENTS: Gandhi walking towards his last prayer meeting



were pictures of the actual trial, held in the Red Fort, showing the Godse brothers, Apte and Karkare looking exceedingly relaxed. There are also photos of the conspirators with Veer Savarkar, the controversial politician, activist and freedom fighter who gave birth to Hindutva. There are the original air tickets bought by the conspirators to fly from Mumbai to Delhi, their hotel bills and the original hand-written FIR filed in Delhi. Godse's family also supplied photos and documents.

The book itself remains the original and, 60 years later, still has the power to bring that epochal event and the protagonists involved back to life. That is partly to do with the research and details dug up by Malgonkar in 1978 and also the treatment. Many of the author's eight novels were racy, full of action and adventure, and he carried that signature style into his historical works.

For history buffs, the addition of new material, even if just photos and some documents, will be a bonus, but for those who have not read the original, the gripping narrative of a group of fanatical conspirators, much like today's suicide bombers, and their blend into a revolutionary story, is well worth reliving that tragic moment in history. ■